Electoral versus census space

From the perspective of the state's access to its peripheries, it is interesting to compare the 2015 partial election cancellations with the 2014 census. There are apparent overlaps in areas where neither the census nor the elections were possible, where enumerators experienced hindrances, or where data for the census were provided by the local administration of armed actors rather than by government enumerators.[16]

The census reports share some information about accessibility and collaboration between the state and ethnic armed actors in ceasefire areas. Apart from Rakhine State, where the government's refusal to allow the term Rohingya as self-ascription led to a situation where the census was not fully conducted in ten out of seventeen townships (see below), the population count also faced accessibility restrictions in Kachin State and Kayin State. In Kachin State, the KIO did not allow enumerators to count people in villages under their control, leaving twenty-five village tracts (ninety-seven villages) out of the census. In parts of Hpapun township of Kayin State, the KNLA denied access to enumerators and provided their own data about the total number of households and population by gender. As a consequence, the populations in these areas were estimated and included in the overall census results, but not in the analysis and presentation of detailed information (MoIP 2015, pp. 8–10).

The Kachin and Hpapun situations during the census parallel the non-accessibility experiences with the establishment of the voter list in these areas. However, the census seems to have been possible in other locations where the voter list was not established, in particular in the Wa SAD townships under UWSA control, and in Mongla, which is under NDAA control. One explanation is that the leaders of these armed groups might have had an interest in knowing how many people reside in their realm, for purposes of recruitment or taxation, but had no interest in their populations' participation in general elections.